



DELHI | Storm Warning

No less than 36 bills are slated to be tabled during the ongoing session of Parliament, including the controversial Nuclear Liability Bill. Given the current pandemonium over the fuel price hike in the Budget, a stormy session lies ahead. The Cabinet recently cleared the Women's Reservation Bill, one of UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi's favourites. With most parties from the cowbelt—the SP, RJD, JD(U) and BSP—opposing it, the UPA is counting on the BJP. Incidentally, nowhere is woman power more evident than in the Lok Sabha with Sonia, leader of the Opposition Sushma Swaraj and Speaker Meira Kumar. But it will take more than this to push the bill through. The Nuclear Liability Bill is a precondition for US companies to enter the civil nuclear sector. The draft of the bill is believed to limit the liability of a foreign operator in case of a nuclear mishap. Though the Cabinet cleared the bill last November, the NDA will oppose it in Parliament. Also on the anvil is a bill to prevent harassment of HIV-positive persons, the Judicial Accountability and Standards Bill to deal with judicial corruption, a road safety bill and one for a regulatory authority for the bio-tech sector, keeping in mind the recent Bt brinjal controversy. Its plate seems rather full but the Government will also have to placate the Opposition as well as some of its own rather vocal allies on the fuel price hike.

MANMOHAN SINGH AND HIS PARLIAMENTARY AFFAIRS TEAM HAVE THEIR WORK CUT OUT

by Priya Sahgal

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bills are slated to be tabled in Parliament during the ongoing session, with the NDA opposing the Nuclear Liability Bill tooth and nail.